



What are secret consumer e-scores?

Secret consumer e-scores are private digital scores that companies use to evaluate the potential value and behavior of consumers as customers. These scores, created through complex algorithms analyzing vast amounts of data—from credit history, job title, income, and property ownership to spending habits on luxury goods or pet supplies—predict how valuable or risky a customer might be for a business. Unlike credit scores, these e-scores are largely secret from consumers and remain proprietary trade secrets. They create a private digital ranking of consumer worth used by businesses to decide how to market to, price for, or prioritize service to individuals.

E-scores extend beyond credit scoring by incorporating detailed lifestyle and behavioral data to forecast purchasing habits and profitability. For example, companies may use them to decide whether a prospective customer is worth marketing to or providing customer service. The algorithms behind these scores are often opaque, unregulated, and can significantly impact how consumers are treated in various industries like retail, finance, education, and online services. Because they are secret, consumers typically do not know their e-scores or how they are calculated, raising concerns about privacy, fairness, and transparency.

These scores are generated and sold by data brokers and specialized firms like eBureau, who aggregate consumer information from multiple sources and apply predictive modeling. The scores can range numerically (e.g., from 0 to 99) and are used internally by companies to make decisions about customers, often without consumer knowledge or consent. The secretive nature of e-scores, their broad data inputs including demographic and behavioral factors, and the significant role they play in consumer interactions underscore the need for greater transparency and regulatory oversight in their use.

In summary, secret consumer e-scores are undisclosed, data-driven numeric ratings that companies use to predict consumers' future value and behavior, influencing marketing, pricing, and customer service decisions while remaining hidden from consumers themselves.^{[1] [2] [3] [4]}

✱✱

Have studies or investigations been conducted of secret e-scores

Yes, there have been studies and investigations into secret consumer e-scores. Academic research and reports have examined the data collection methods, the proprietary algorithms, and the societal effects of these secret scores. These studies highlight concerns about privacy, fairness, and transparency because consumers are generally unaware of these scores, how they

are calculated, or how they influence marketing and service decisions. Some investigations show these scores create divisions between "haves" and "have-nots" by using intrusive data to rate consumer value and potential profitability. Regulatory scrutiny like that from the Federal Trade Commission has also been triggered by the opaque nature of these scores.

Notably, research has explored how secret consumer scores use vast data sources, including credit information, lifestyle details, and purchasing habits, to predict future behavior and value. There are studies testing how consumers feel about secrecy in purchases linked to these scores, such as guilt and brand connection. However, the algorithms remain trade secrets, and consumers cannot access or challenge their scores, raising questions about due process and discrimination. Overall, these studies emphasize the need for transparency and oversight to protect consumers from potentially unfair treatment driven by secretive e-scores. [\[8\]](#) [\[9\]](#) [\[10\]](#) [\[11\]](#)



Provide copies of these studies

There are some key studies and reports available about secret consumer e-scores and related secret consumer behaviors:

1. A research paper titled "Understanding Secret Consumer Purchases and Their Effects on Brands" examines how brands help consumers keep purchases secret, how this secrecy affects feelings such as guilt and satisfaction, and how it relates to brand connection. It includes pilot studies and analyses of scenarios like disguised credit card names and discrete packaging. The study shows how secrecy methods impact consumer feelings and brand perceptions, highlighting marketing insights for brands. [\[16\]](#)
2. A legal article titled "Secret Consumer Scores and Segmentations: Separating 'Haves' and 'Have-Nots'" explores how secret consumer scores use big data and predictive analytics to rank consumers. It discusses the secretive nature of these scores, data broker practices, discriminatory impacts, and the lack of consumer awareness or recourse. It sheds light on the socio-economic implications of secret e-scores and calls for regulatory oversight. [\[17\]](#)
3. A report named "How Secret Consumer Scores Threaten Your Privacy and Your Future" addresses the risks posed by opaque predictive consumer scoring models. It highlights privacy, fairness, and due process issues due to the secretive way these scores are compiled and used, often without consumer knowledge. [\[18\]](#)

These documents are available online as PDFs or articles and provide detailed insights and empirical findings on secret e-scores and secret consumer behaviors. They represent some of the prominent academic and investigative work on the topic. However, the actual proprietary algorithms behind e-scores remain trade secrets and are not publicly disclosed.

If desired, the full PDFs can be accessed through the respective links for detailed reading.

These studies collectively reveal the secretive, impactful, and often controversial role of e-scores in modern consumer markets, emphasizing both business value and consumer protection challenges. [\[16\]](#) [\[17\]](#) [\[18\]](#)



1. <https://www.nytimes.com/2012/08/19/business/electronic-scores-rank-consumers-by-potential-value.html>
2. <https://lawweb.colorado.edu/profiles/pubpdfs/schmitz/eScores.pdf>
3. https://worldprivacyforum.org/documents/122/WPF_Scoring_of_America_April2014_fs.pdf
4. <https://www.synchrony.com/blog/banking/your-secret-consumer-score>
5. <https://watchdognation.com/the-watchdog-secret-scores-supposedly-reveal-who-consumers-are/>
6. <https://www.inc.com/bill-murphy-jr/secret-consumer-scores-explain-why-some-people-get-much-better-service-than-others-now-you-can-finally-request-your-data-get-your-file.html>
7. <https://sarahslawfirm.com/2020/01/secret-consumer-scores-affect-how-companies-treat-you/>
8. <https://scholars.unh.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1601&context=honors>
9. <https://lawweb.colorado.edu/profiles/pubpdfs/schmitz/eScores.pdf>
10. https://worldprivacyforum.org/documents/122/WPF_Scoring_of_America_April2014_fs.pdf
11. <https://phys.org/news/2014-03-little-known-scores-consumers-based-web.html>
12. <https://www.nytimes.com/2012/08/19/business/electronic-scores-rank-consumers-by-potential-value.html>
13. https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=2617502
14. <https://scholarship.law.missouri.edu/facpubs/612/>
15. <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0022435999000044>
16. <https://scholars.unh.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1601&context=honors>
17. <https://lawweb.colorado.edu/profiles/pubpdfs/schmitz/eScores.pdf>
18. https://worldprivacyforum.org/documents/122/WPF_Scoring_of_America_April2014_fs.pdf
19. <https://www.nytimes.com/2012/08/19/business/electronic-scores-rank-consumers-by-potential-value.html>
20. https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=2617502
21. <https://scholarship.law.missouri.edu/facpubs/612/>
22. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9216200/>
23. https://convention2.allacademic.com/one/scp/scp20/online_program_direct_link/view_paper/1593768/
24. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/EJ992983.pdf>